

**Board 2**

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 4  
 ♥ Q 7 5 3 2  
 ♦ A 9 3  
 ♣ 8 6 3

♠ K J 6 5

♥ A K

♦ Q 8 7

♣ A K 7 4



♠ Q 8 3  
 ♥ J 10 8 4  
 ♦ K 10 6 2  
 ♣ 10 2

♠ A 10 7 2

♥ 9 6

♦ J 5 4

♣ Q J 9 5

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          | 2NT   | Pass | 3♣    |
| Pass     | 3♠    | Pass | 4♠    |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

4♠ by North  
the ♥K.

North is to play 4♠ after South's Stayman bid uncovered the 4-4 fit. East leads the ♥J which you win the your ♥A.

With three possible losers in ♦s you might first think that you will have to finesse one of the defenders for the trump Queen. But anytime you see an unsupported Jack opposite an unsupported Queen you should start thinking about a throw-in play. And what better card to use for the throw-in than the Queen of trumps.

So pull two rounds of trumps with the ♠A and ♠K, hoping the ♠Q falls. She doesn't fall, but both defenders do follow suit. So the ♠Q is the only trump outstanding.

Next eliminate ♥s from you and dummy by playing

Now play four rounds of ♣s to eliminate that suit. If a defender decides to ruff one of these ♣s with the master trump he will be end-played, forced to either play a ♦ or to give you a ruff-sluff. So assume that all four ♣s win tricks.

Now you administer the coup de gras, you lead a trump.

[showcards N:ST,DJ,D5,D4 S:SJ,DQ,D8,D7]

One of the defenders has won the ♠Q. Too bad for him. If he now plays a ♦ you will make either the ♦Q or ♦J. If he plays a ♥ you will ruff in one hand and discard a ♦ loser from the other.

It is clear that the elimination play saved you having to guess the finesse for the ♠Q.

But what if you considered yourself a really good guesser? So good that you felt confident in taking the finesse, and so good that you pulled it off successfully.

You'd be no better off. Although you would avoid the ♠ loser you would now have to play the ♦s for yourself and you would lose three ♦s!

**Board 4**

North Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 9 7 2  
 ♥ K 10 7 4  
 ♦ Q 8 2  
 ♣ 7

♠ Q 5

♥ A J 6 2

♦ A 9 6 4

♣ A J 5

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ K 8 6 3

♥ Q 9 8 3

♦ 10 7 5

♣ 8 2

♠ A 4

♥ 5

♦ K J 3

♣ K Q 10 9 6 4 3

| West        | North | East | South |
|-------------|-------|------|-------|
|             | 1NT   | Pass | 3♣    |
| Pass        | 4♣    | Pass | 6♣    |
| All Pass    |       |      |       |
| 6♣ by South |       |      |       |

South considered Blackwood, then realized if North showed either 2 or 3 Aces he was going to bid slam. But if North showed just one Ace he would have to maneuver to play 5NT which might be worse than 6♣. So he just bid the slam. South plays 6♣. West leads the ♠J.

You wish, you hope, you may even pray, but when you play the ♠Q East covers with the ♠K. So you know you have a ♠ loser. And unless East holds the ♦Q you might have a ♦ loser also.

Perhaps an elimination play will improve your chances. Don't lead a trump yet though, you're going to need several entries to dummy to eliminate the ♥s.

Win the ♠, play to the ♥A and ruff a ♥.

Play a trump to dummy's ♣J (both defenders follow) and ruff another ♥ high.

Play to dummy's ♣A, pulling their last trump, and ruff the last ♥.

Now execute the throw-in by leading a ♠. If West wins the trick he will have to play ♦s for you or give you a ruff-sluff. So if these are competent defenders they will make sure that it is **EAST** who wins the ♠ trick. So he does, and he plays a small ♦.

**DO NOT PLAY THE JACK!** If the finesse is going to work now it will still work one trick later. By playing low you take advantage of the possibility that East held the ♦10 and West will have to put on the ♦Q to prevent you taking a trick with dummy's ♦9.

Many elimination endings give you a sure thing. Others just improve your chances.

Here you had two chances. First, West might have HAD to win the throw-in, either because he had all of the high ♠s, or more likely because he messed up. The second chance paid off when East took the throw-in but you found a fortunate position with the ♦s.